■■ The Torchbearer's Checklist

What to do when someone you love is suffering silently

■ Don’t ask first — be present first

→ Presence speaks before questions ever can.

■ Stop offering advice

→ Unless they ask, advice adds pressure, not help.

■ Validate, don’t fix

→ Say: “That sounds heavy. I’m here.” Don’t say: “Try yoga” or “Be grateful.”

■ Be willing to feel awkward or powerless

→ That’s where true empathy begins.

■ Stay even after they smile

→ A smile can be survival, not recovery.

■ Educate yourself quietly

→ Learn about what they’re going through. Don’t make them teach you.

■ Return consistently without expectation

→ Healing doesn’t happen on your timeline.

■ Trust their truth even if it doesn’t make sense to you

→ Their haunted house isn’t yours to understand fully — only to respect.